LA CUCINA ITALIANA - SEMPLICE ITALIAN KITCHEN | QUICK ITALIAN DINNERS

5-Ingredient Italian Pantry Dinners (Ready in 20 Minutes with Everyday Staples)

Turn 5 everyday pantry staples into restaurant-quality Italian dinners in 20 minutes! Includes our master Pantry Pasta formula, variations, and a free PDF card.

Prep: 5 mins | Cook: 15 mins | Total: 20 mins | Yield: 4 servings | Calories: 480 kcal

INGREDIENTS CHECKLIST

[ ] 400g (14 oz) 1. Bronze-Die Spaghetti or Bucatini
[ ] 60ml (1/4 cup) 2. Extra Virgin Olive Oil
[ ] 6 cloves 3. Fresh Garlic Cloves (thinly shaved)
[ ] 80g 4. Aged Pecorino Romano or Parmigiano-Reggiano (finely grated)
[ ] 1 tsp chili flakes, 1/2 cup crumbs 5. Crushed Calabrian Chili Flakes (or Toasted Breadcrumbs)

STEP-BY-STEP CULINARY INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Boil Pasta in Concentrating Salted Water [8 mins]

Cook spaghetti in a wide pot with 3 quarts of salted water until 2 minutes shy of al dente. Reserve 1.5 cups of starchy cooking water.

Step 2: Cold-Pan Garlic & Chili Infusion [4 mins]

Place sliced garlic, chili flakes, and olive oil in a cold skillet, then bring to medium-low heat for 4 minutes until the garlic turns pale golden and sweet.

Step 3: The 2-Minute Starch Emulsion (Mantecatura) [2 mins]

Transfer dripping pasta directly into the garlic oil skillet along with 3/4 cup starchy pasta water. Simmer and toss vigorously for 2 minutes until the water and oil emulsify into a creamy glaze.

Step 4: Toss Off-Heat with Grated Cheese

Remove pan from heat, shower with finely grated Pecorino Romano (and toasted breadcrumbs if using), toss for 30 seconds, and serve immediately.

CHEF'S PRO TIPS & STORAGE

* The secret to 5-ingredient Italian pantry dinners (like Aglio e Olio, Cacio e Pepe, and Carbonara) is Mantecatura: tossing undercooked pasta in the skillet with starchy water so the sauce thickens naturally.
* Always start sliced garlic in cold olive oil-this extracts maximum aroma without turning the edges bitter.